

SECTION THREE

CULTURE, CUSTOMS & DAILY LIFE

> **How to Use This Section:** *This is the largest section in the workbook, covering everything from daily routines to courtship to exile. You don't need to answer every question. Questions marked ♦ **Core** are the essentials; start there. All other questions are Deep Dive, so use them when you need more detail for a specific area of your story. Use the Section Map below to jump to what matters most, and skip anything that doesn't serve your romance.*

Culture is the texture of your world. It's the unwritten rules everyone knows, the rituals that mark important moments, the things people do without thinking about them. How they greet each other, what they eat, what they believe about luck, how they raise their children, and what they do for fun. And in romantasy, culture is the invisible architecture that determines what your characters can and can't do, what it costs them to step out of line, and what hoops they've got to jump through to be together.

The “Invisible Cage” Principle

Cultural boundaries create some of the most compelling constraints when they're so much a part of your character's world view that they're unseen by themselves. What we call love is what brings these into focus.

A character who's never questioned arranged marriage doesn't experience it as oppression until they want to marry someone else. A character who assumes certain others are inferior to them doesn't recognise the limitations of their assumptions until they develop romantic feelings for one of those people. Those bars were always there. It's when your character wants something on the other side of those bars that they begin to realise there are limits.

Feyre in *ACOTAR* is an excellent illustration of this. She never questions Tamlin's protective nature or the rules of the Spring Court until she experiences Rhysand's Night Court, where she's given autonomy and actual choice. It was only through experiencing love from someone who treats her differently that Feyre realises the cage she has been living in. And the cage she had been living in wasn't due to Tamlin's cruelty. It was Feyre genuinely believing that's what love looked like.

What does your character take for granted that love will make them realise?

- **Unquestioned norms:** “This is just how things are done.” Until doing things differently becomes the only way to be with the person they want.
- **Invisible hierarchies:** Differences in status that are normal to the character with the higher status but felt to be oppressive to the other character. The tension exists at the point when the privileged one finally sees it.
- **Internalised shame:** Characters that feel unworthy of love because their culture taught them they're less than others. Their partner will need to battle those feelings along with each external challenge.
- **Loyalty costs:** To choose love is to betray community, family, and tradition. The identity that the character held prior to love won't exist any more; the new one will be something that their previous self wouldn't recognise. That transformation *is* the story.

The invisible cage works because culture creates identity. Disobeying the law is an action. Defying your culture is an identity crisis. When your characters choose to follow their heart rather than their traditions, they aren't merely breaking rules. They're creating an entirely new identity for themselves, and that *is* the story.

Brain Dump: What Does Your Culture Look Like?

Before mapping how culture creates romantic tension, get your initial vision down. What kind of society are your characters living in?

Describe your world's culture in broad strokes.

What kind of society is this? What are the big rules everyone follows? What does daily life feel like? Don't worry about details yet; just get the general picture on the page.

(Write your answer below)



♦ Core: What are the most important social rules people follow without questioning them?

Think about hierarchy, gender, class, religion, family. What do people accept as “just the way things are”?

YOUR ANSWER

How to Think About Culture in Romantasy

Culture in romantasy is a constraint system. It's the social rules that determine what your characters can and can't do, what it costs them to step out of line, and what hoops they have to jump through to be together.

The tighter the constraints, the higher the tension. A culture where unmarried people can't be alone together makes every stolen moment electric. Loose constraints work too, but then your tension needs to come from somewhere else.

Don't explain culture through exposition. Let readers discover the rules when characters follow them, break them, or face consequences for crossing them. A single scene of social awkwardness teaches more than a paragraph of worldbuilding ever could.

Culture as Obstacle

The rules your characters must navigate or break:

- Taboos against certain relationships (class, species, enemy nations)
- Required courtship progressions that can't be skipped
- Chaperoning requirements that prevent privacy
- Reputation systems where being seen together causes damage
- Family involvement that creates external opposition

Culture as Opportunity

The customs that create romantic moments:

- Festivals where normal rules relax
- Dances that allow sanctioned touch
- Gift-giving traditions that let characters express interest
- Ceremonies that force proximity
- Traditions that create meaningful gestures

Culture as Revelation

How characters interact with cultural expectations shows who they are:

- Do they follow rules out of belief or fear?
- Do they break rules impulsively or deliberately?
- Do they chafe against expectations or never question them?

Some of the most interesting romantic tension comes from pairing characters who relate to their culture differently. One who embodies its values, one who challenges them.

Common Patterns: Culture in Romantasy

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The forbidden touch	Culture restricts physical contact; every brush of hands becomes charged	Slow-burn tension; meaningful small gestures
The reputation gamble	Being seen together risks social ruin	Stakes for every private moment; secrets
The courtship ladder	Expected progression that can't be skipped	Frustration when feelings outpace propriety
The chaperoned dance	Must interact under watchful eyes	Stolen glances; coded communication
The festival exception	One night when rules relax	Pivotal scenes; masks and anonymity
The cultural mistranslation	Gesture means different things in different cultures	Misunderstanding; revelation when explained

Which of these obstacles exist in your world?

Pick the ones that apply from the lists and table above, and note how they show up.

YOUR ANSWER

What cultural traditions in your world create opportunities for closeness?

Think about festivals, dances, ceremonies, or gift-giving customs that give characters an excuse to be near each other.

YOUR ANSWER

Applying the Principle: The Invisible Cage

Now that you've established what your culture looks like, return to the Invisible Cage principle from above.

The Key Question

What does your character believe is “just how things are” at the start of the story? What will falling for this person force them to see differently?

Map your character's invisible cage:

The invisible cage only becomes visible when your character wants something on the other side of the bars. This is the moment when culture stops being background and becomes the central obstacle of your romance.

For each character: What rule do they follow without thinking? What moment makes them see the cage? What do they lose by seeing it, and what do they gain?

(Write your answer below)

How does each character relate to their culture's rules?

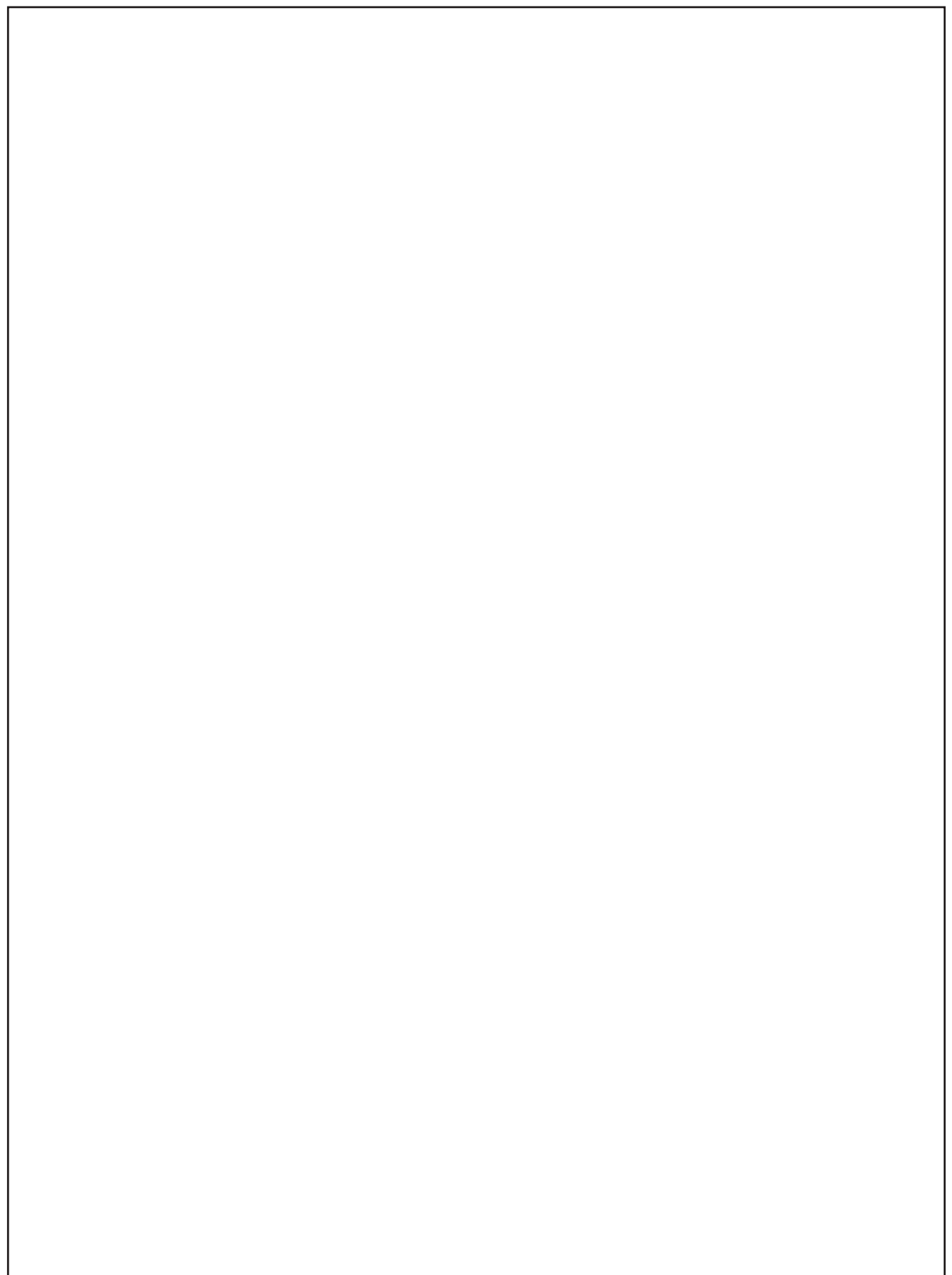
Do they follow the rules because they believe, or because they fear? Do they break rules on impulse or on purpose? Pairing characters who relate to culture differently creates natural tension.

YOUR ANSWER

Which 2-3 patterns from the table above show up in your world?

For each one you pick, describe how it works in your story.

(Write your answer below)



A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. Skip what doesn't fit.

If your world mirrors a real culture, focus on what's different. You don't need to invent every custom from scratch. Zero in on what deviates from what readers will assume, and on the elements that create friction for your romance.

Quick Guide to What You Need

Every story needs: Core cultural values, daily routines, and what social rules shape your characters' lives.

If your romance crosses cultural boundaries: Focus on Core Values, Taboos, and Cultural Differences.

If your romance involves courtship customs: Focus on Gender Roles, Touch & Boundaries, Courtship, and Marriage.

If class or status divides your characters: Focus on Social Class, Manners & Etiquette, and Reputation.

If you're not sure yet: Start with the Brain Dump and Core Values. You can always come back.

Section Map

This section covers a lot of ground. Here's what's ahead so you can plan your time:

- **Part 1: Foundations** : Values, Gender, Daily Life, Home, Family, Food, Architecture
- **Part 2: Social Rules** : Religion, Superstitions, Manners, Hospitality, Entertainment, Humour, Oaths
- **Part 3: Boundaries & Identity** : Taboos, Sexuality, Reputation, Privacy, Touch, Beauty, Dress
- **Part 4: Milestones & Rituals** : Courtship, Tokens, Marriage, Death, Life Stages, Children, Work, Outsiders
- **Part 5: Culture in Action** : Festivals, Exile, Social Hierarchy, Cultural Differences, Integration Check

Common Mistakes with Cultural Worldbuilding

Mistake #1: The Inconsistent Culture

Cultural rules apply when convenient and disappear when inconvenient. Characters are chaperoned in one scene and alone together the next with no explanation. Stakes that come and go feel fake. If readers can't trust that the rules are real, they won't feel tension about breaking them.

FIX

Establish your rules clearly and enforce them consistently. If characters break rules, show consequences. If rules relax in certain circumstances, establish that pattern early.

Mistake #2: The Paper-Thin Taboo

Something is supposedly forbidden, but no one seems to actually care. The “forbidden” lovers face disapproval but no real consequences. Forbidden love only matters if the forbidding is real. Stakes need teeth.

FIX

Make consequences concrete and serious. Show other characters who suffered these consequences so readers know the threat is genuine.

Mistake #3: The Monolithic Culture

Everyone in a society thinks the same way, follows the same rules. No internal variation, no rebels, no regional differences.

FIX

Show variation. Some people enforce rules strictly; others look the other way. Older and younger generations may differ. Your characters should be able to find allies and enemies within their own culture.



Cultural Worldbuilding Self-Check

Review the culture you’ve built so far. Check any that apply, then address the ones that need fixing.

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Inconsistent Culture: Rules apply when convenient and disappear when inconvenient		

MISTAKE	DOES THIS APPLY TO YOU?	WHAT TO FIX
Paper-Thin Taboo: Something is supposedly forbidden, but no one seems to actually care and there are no real consequences		
Monolithic Culture: Everyone in the society thinks the same way with no internal variation, rebels, or regional differences		

Who in your world disagrees with the mainstream culture?

Every society has dissenters – older generations vs. younger, city vs. rural, reformers vs. traditionalists. Who pushes back against the dominant culture, and how?

YOUR ANSWER

Now that you've identified the broad shape of your culture and its potential pitfalls, it's time to dig into the specifics, starting with the beliefs that sit at the foundation of everything else.

Core Values & Worldview

Every single culture teaches its own set of fundamental beliefs: the virtues people learn in childhood, the attributes that make a person worthy of respect, the shortcomings that lead to shame. Your characters develop as a result of being shaped by those belief systems, even when they resist.

Because your characters are from different cultures, they have been raised on different values. So when their values collide (which will eventually happen), there's natural, authentic conflict. Let your characters grapple with fundamentally different views of life. The romance will grow stronger when they have to make genuine changes, not merely acceptance.

The Key Question

Which cultural values must your characters compromise or sacrifice to be together?

Reference: Cultural Values & Traits

Use this list when deciding what your culture values most. Pick 3-5 that define your world.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE VALUES
Personal Virtues	Honour, loyalty, courage, humility, patience, wisdom, honesty, compassion, self-reliance, cunning
Social Bonds	Family duty, clan loyalty, hospitality, community harmony, respect for elders, friendship, romantic love
Achievement	Ambition, excellence, competition, innovation, artistic mastery, scholarly pursuit, martial prowess
Spiritual	Piety, ritual observance, connection to ancestors, mystical insight, fate acceptance, divine service
Material	Wealth, status, land ownership, beautiful possessions, comfort, security, legacy
Freedom	Independence, personal choice, adventure, wanderlust, self-expression, breaking tradition
Order	Tradition, hierarchy, obedience, propriety, law, duty, sacrifice for the greater good

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE VALUES
Power	Strength, dominance, conquest, political influence, magical ability, control, leadership

♦ **Core: What does your culture value most highly?**

List 3-5 core values in order of importance:

What does your culture consider shameful or dishonourable?

The flip side of values, what brings disgrace:

YOUR ANSWER

Where does each character fit with these values, and where do they push back?

Think about your protagonist and love interest separately. Which cultural values feel natural to them, and which ones chafe?

(Write your answer below)

How do these values create tension for your characters?

Think about where your characters' values clash – with each other's, or with what love demands.

YOUR ANSWER

What value must your characters give up to be together?

What virtue do they have to abandon, or what shame must they accept?

YOUR ANSWER

Cultural Change

Every culture is in motion. Older generations cling to tradition while younger ones push for something different. Identifying what's shifting in your world right now gives your romance a sense of momentum and makes characters feel like they exist within a living society rather than a static one.

What's changing in your culture right now?

What custom or belief is losing its grip? What new idea is gaining ground? How does this shift affect your characters' options?

YOUR ANSWER

What do older people complain about? What do younger people want?

The generational divide tells readers where the culture has been and where it's headed. Which side of the divide are your characters on?

YOUR ANSWER

Is the change your characters want already happening in the wider culture, or are they ahead of it?

IS THE CHANGE YOUR CHARACTERS WANT ALREADY HAPPENING IN THE WIDER CULTURE,
OR ARE THEY AHEAD OF IT?

◆ **Checkpoint: Values & Identity**

Pause and look at your answers so far. Do your culture's core values create a genuine obstacle for your romance, or could your characters get together without much resistance? If the values you picked don't generate real tension, consider swapping in ones that do.

Values shape what your culture believes. Gender roles shape what your culture expects people to *do*, and that distinction matters for every relationship in your story.

Gender Roles & Expectations

Gender (or equivalent social categories in your world) shapes behaviour, opportunities, and relationship dynamics. Societal expectations dictate who pursues and who waits, who has agency and who defers. This affects everything that follows: daily life, family, courtship, hierarchy, and what your characters are even allowed to want.

Show gender constraints through small friction points rather than big dramatic confrontations: the dress that limits movement, the conversation she's excluded from, the assumption made about her desires without asking. Don't overlook the costs of conformity either: the mental fatigue, the emotional exhaustion, the sorrow for choices not made. The space between how society views your characters and how their lover views them is precisely where the romance lives.

♦ **Core: What roles and behaviours does your culture expect based on gender?**

What are people supposed to do, and what are they forbidden from doing? Focus on what affects your story. (Write your answer below)

♦ **Core: How can you tell someone's social class just by looking at them?**

Think about clothing, posture, speech patterns, where they walk, what they carry. What signals status at a glance?

YOUR ANSWER

How do gender expectations limit your protagonist? Your love interest?

What can't they do, say, or want because of their gender?

(Write your answer below)

How does either character break gender expectations?

What do they do, and what consequences do they face?

YOUR ANSWER

How do gender expectations shape courtship?

Who pursues? Who waits? Who controls the pace?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when the “wrong” person takes the lead in courtship?

What happens when someone defies the expected courtship dynamic – the woman proposing, the lower-status person initiating? The reaction shows how rigid your culture really is.

YOUR ANSWER



Gender expectations set the boundaries. Now consider what happens inside those boundaries. Now consider what happens inside them: the ordinary rhythms of life that romance will disrupt.

Daily Life & Routines

To understand how culture shapes romantic experiences, you have to begin with how people live their lives. Romance occurs in the context of daily routines. Examining the patterns of living reveals when a couple will encounter each other and what's considered "normal."

The number of routines you choose to depict isn't as important as establishing a baseline for readers' perception of what's normal and how much of an impact a deviation from that norm has. A couple of lines about a character's morning rituals (they always take their tea; they always say their prayers) illustrate what a distraction or change means. Routine is a good method for developing character as well: what does the character do first? When in a rush, what does the character skip? What's the small comfort the character would never give up no matter what?

As soon as romance enters into a character's routine, the reader will be able to sense the difference due to the prior knowledge of what was considered "normal." Their character begins to wake up thinking of someone. The regular walk back home has new feelings because there could be this person. These little changes resonate with the reader because the reader understands the context from before.

♦ Core: What does a typical day look like from morning to night?

When do people wake? What happens first? Is there a midday rest or main meal? When does work end? What fills the evening?

(Write your answer below)

How does this rhythm differ by class or profession?

HOW DOES THIS RHYTHM DIFFER BY CLASS OR PROFESSION?

What does your world sound, smell, and feel like during a typical day?

Think about the morning market, the midday heat, the evening fires. What would a stranger notice first?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the weekly or monthly rhythm?

Market days? Rest days? Religious observances? Regular social gatherings?

YOUR ANSWER

What do people do when they're not working?

Leisure, entertainment, socialising. What fills non-work hours?

YOUR ANSWER

What do ordinary people worry about day to day?

Money? Safety? Harvest? Their children's futures? A character's everyday concerns ground them in the world and tell the reader what kind of life they lead.

YOUR ANSWER

♦ **Core: How do people treat strangers or newcomers?**

Are outsiders welcomed, tolerated, or feared? What does a newcomer have to do to be accepted?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the love interest change your protagonist's daily routine?

Pick one specific routine element and describe it before and after. What shifts when your protagonist starts thinking about this person?

(Write your answer below)

Cross-check: Does the daily routine you described match your technology level? If your world lacks indoor plumbing or electric light, daily life should reflect that. See Section 9: Technology & Infrastructure.



You've established how your characters move through the world. Now consider the spaces they move through, starting with where they live.

Home & Household

Your home is the most intimate space in your world. It's the place where characters are most themselves. The way homes are constructed, how many people share them, and the amount of privacy they provide all shape when and where your characters can be vulnerable with each other. Homes shared with servants or other people create vastly different possibilities for romance than homes lived in alone.

How your point-of-view character reacts (or doesn't react) to what they see upon entering a home is an indicator of their past experience. A character raised in poverty will count every single thing of value; a character from wealth will likely never recognise anything about their surroundings as luxurious, but rather notice immediately if something feels wrong. Instead of saying "the home was rich" use specific objects like "silver candlesticks left casually on a side table, more books than she'd seen in her life, a fire burning in an empty room."

As your character first enters their love interest's home, take some time to allow them to understand who this person is based upon where they live. That's a type of intimacy in itself.

What does home look like for the wealthy, the middle class, and the poor?

(Write your answer below)

Who lives together?

Nuclear families? Extended families? Multiple generations? Servants in the household? Unmarried adults with parents?

YOUR ANSWER

How much privacy exists within a home?

Private bedrooms? Shared sleeping spaces? Thin walls? Servants everywhere?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a house a “home”?

What objects, rituals, or elements make a space feel like home in your culture?

YOUR ANSWER

What does your protagonist notice when they first enter the love interest’s home?

A home reveals who someone truly is. What details catch your protagonist’s eye. What do those details tell them?

YOUR ANSWER



Daily routines establish the rhythm of life. Family is what gives that rhythm its emotional weight, and its obligations.

Family Structure & Relationships

Your characters' family is where their identity is formed prior to the story beginning; and also what they'll be answering to once the story has begun. Expectations from their parents, siblings and other relatives will have commitments that conflict with those of romantic interests. In romantasy, family often acts as the first and most personal obstacle to finding true love.

A character caught between their feelings for another person and their obligation to their family is making a decision that your readers will relate to on a visceral level. You can show family dynamics through the little things: who speaks first at dinner, who always gives in to whom, whose opinion really matters even if there isn't an established order of authority. Approval from family members (and the lack of it) can speed up or kill a romance, and when a love interest gains the acceptance of a difficult parent, the reader also views this as a victory.

What's the typical family structure?

Who heads the household? How are decisions made? What's the hierarchy within a family?

YOUR ANSWER

What obligations exist between family members?

What do children owe parents? What do parents owe children? What about siblings, extended family?

YOUR ANSWER

How are children raised?

Who raises them (parents, extended family, nurses, community)? What are they taught? When do they start working or training?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens to orphans, unmarried adults, elderly without children?

How does the culture handle people outside the typical family structure?

YOUR ANSWER

How does family affect your characters' romance?

Whose approval matters? Who will try to interfere? What power does a parent or elder hold over the match?

What's each character's family's stance on the relationship, and what power do they have to interfere?

(Write your answer below)



Family determines who your characters answer to. Food determines how they gather, and sharing a meal is one of the oldest ways to build intimacy.

Food & Meals

Food shows culture. The foods we eat, the ways we prepare them, and with whom we eat them can tell you a great deal about values, resources, and social bonds.

Don't have to invent a whole cuisine. Just focus on those aspects of food which will be relevant to your story: what would your characters share over a meal? What meal will they make for someone they love?

Eating together is one of the most simple ways to develop intimacy. When characters first begin to eat together, pay close attention to what they notice about each other's habits. Is she picking at her food? Is he eating as if he has no idea when his next meal will come? Cooking for someone is an act of caring. Use this in your writing. Refusing to eat with someone, or eating by yourself when you can be sharing a meal, also means something. To create a food scene that works well, you should slow down on the detail of the senses: the smell of the food, the warmth of a shared cup, the way a character tears apart their bread. Let the physical action of eating together do all the emotional work.

♦ **Core: What do people eat, and how do they eat it?**

Describe morning, midday, and evening meals. Do people eat alone, communally, or formally? Meals give you the raw material for scenes that do emotional heavy lifting.

(Write your answer below)

What's "special occasion" food vs. everyday food?

WHAT'S "SPECIAL OCCASION" FOOD VS. EVERYDAY FOOD?

What food rules or restrictions exist?

Religious restrictions? Class-based foods? Regional specialties? Seasonal availability?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the culture around drinking (alcohol or otherwise)?

When is drinking appropriate? What's drunk? What are drinking customs?

YOUR ANSWER



What are the rules around shared meals?

Who can eat together? Who eats first? Who serves? Are there forbidden combinations (class, gender, species)?

YOUR ANSWER

What does sharing a meal signify?

Friendship? Alliance? Courtship? Family acceptance? Sealing a deal?

YOUR ANSWER

What foods or drinks have romantic or special meaning?

Aphrodisiacs, festival foods, courting treats, magical foods:

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a meal where something important happens between your characters?

Food scenes do emotional heavy lifting: the shared cup, the meal cooked with care, the silence over a table.

What's the setting? What's eaten? What happens?

YOUR ANSWER

◆ Checkpoint: Daily Life & Domestic World

Look back at your answers on daily routines, home life, family, and food. Does everything fit together? If your culture prizes communal meals but you described nuclear families living alone, decide which one wins. Small contradictions now become plot holes later.

From the intimate spaces of home and table, we move outward to the built environment, the structures your characters navigate every day.

Architecture & Building

The way that people construct buildings can tell us a lot about who they are. A desert palace won't look anything like a northern fortress. No degree in architecture is required to recognise this.

All you really need to do is think about what would make sense with regards to each environment. In hot climates it's essential to create shade and allow for airflow. In cold climates, it's necessary to create thick walls that can keep the cold out, as well as large fireplaces that provide warmth. These differences in climate will give your readers a sense of place when travelling from one region to another. (For more on how climate shapes building, see Section 1: Geography & Environment.)

The way you construct your scenes can also impact the development of those scenes in practical ways. Narrow corridors force characters to stand close together. Great halls allow for a wide separation of characters across large tables. And the person that knows where all of the hidden passages are has the upper hand over the person that doesn't. When you're thinking about romantic scenes, consider how the layout of the room impacts the distance between characters, the amount of privacy they have, and the power dynamic of the scene.

What architectural style dominates your main setting?

Research real-world architecture that inspires your world. Note distinctive elements like columns, arches, domes, and materials.

YOUR ANSWER

What are buildings made from, and why?

Building materials tell readers about the landscape and climate. Stone in a quarry region, wood where forests are thick, adobe in dry heat. What's available, and what does it say about the environment?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes different buildings recognisable at a glance?

How can your protagonist tell a temple from a tavern? Think about palaces, temples, merchant homes, common dwellings, and fortifications.

(Write your answer below)

How does a specific building's layout shape a scene between your characters?

Narrow corridors force proximity. Great halls create distance. Hidden passages give one character power over another. Pick a key setting and describe how its layout affects the dynamic.

(Write your answer below)



Architecture shapes the physical world your characters inhabit. Religion shapes the invisible one, the beliefs, rituals, and spiritual habits woven into everyday life.

Religion & Spirituality in Daily Life

If religion has been a key aspect of your story, consider expanding upon it in Section 6: Religion, Myth & Prophecy. Focus on how religion is part of the everyday lives of your characters.

A person's religion in everyday life is based on habits, not theology. The small rituals people go through without thinking, the phrases that are spoken without thought, and the gestures that mark the different stages of each day. They provide for your world the "lived-in" quality, and help create a common (or conflicting) spiritual vocabulary among your characters.

Most religions are rooted in the small things: how someone prays before a meal, what someone says when receiving bad news, and a shrine that's in almost every home. Inevitably, when two characters' religions clash, there'll be conflict; and when two characters quietly pray together, there's intimacy. A character finding out that their love interest knows their prayer, or mouthing along with a blessing they don't believe in simply because they want to show respect, is an intimate gesture that provides significant romantic impact.

♦ **Core: What role does religion/spirituality play in daily life?**

These details will determine whether your characters share a spiritual vocabulary or must navigate different faiths, both of which shape the intimacy available to them.

Daily prayers or rituals? Religious dietary restrictions? Spiritual interpretations of everyday events?

YOUR ANSWER

What life events have religious significance?

Birth, coming of age, marriage, death. What rituals mark these transitions?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people interact with religious institutions or figures?

Priests, temples, shrines. How present are they in ordinary life?

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered sacred or profane?

What places, objects, words, or actions carry spiritual weight?

YOUR ANSWER

How religious is an ordinary person compared to a devout one?

What's the difference between someone who goes through the motions and someone who truly believes? Where do your characters fall on that spectrum?

YOUR ANSWER

How does religion create tension or intimacy between your characters?

Do they pray to different gods? Does one character's faith demand something the other can't give? Is there a moment when one character quietly joins in the other's practice out of respect?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Is what you described here consistent with the full religion you built in Section 6: Religion, Myth & Prophecy? Daily spiritual habits should flow from the theology and institutions you established there.

Formal religion is what people profess. Superstition is what they actually do without thinking, and those unconscious habits often reveal more about a culture than any creed.

Superstitions & Folk Beliefs

Beyond formal religion, most cultures have their own folk beliefs. These are things everyone knows even though they can't tell you how they know. This little stuff makes a world that feels lived in.

These small superstitions will also show you how a person thinks by showing their character through what they do, not just by telling you. A hard-boiled soldier who still won't walk underneath a ladder tells you something that could never be told with words. Folk beliefs can generate small moments of connection or conflict for your characters too. Is one of your characters charmed by the other's superstition, or do they think they're foolish? If a superstition comes true, it could knock the ground right from underneath your characters' feet. And there's something sweet about a character that doesn't believe in good luck still carrying a charm because the person they love gave it to them.

Reference: Common Superstitions & Omens

Use this list for inspiration. Pick a few that fit your world's mood and culture.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Lucky/Unlucky Numbers	Three for luck, seven for magic, thirteen cursed, odd numbers for the living, even for the dead
Animal Omens	Ravens mean death, white animals are blessed, black cats bring luck (or doom), owls warn of secrets
Weather Signs	Red sky warnings, thunder during weddings, rain on a journey's start, fog hiding spirits
Protective Actions	Iron wards off fae, salt purifies, crossing thresholds with right foot, spitting to avert evil eye
Bad Luck Triggers	Speaking a dead person's name, whistling at night, opening umbrellas indoors, breaking mirrors
Good Luck Rituals	Knocking wood, throwing coins in water, carrying charms, first-footing at new year, bride's "something old"

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Threshold Beliefs	Don't step on cracks, carry brides over doorways, leave offerings at crossroads, dawn/dusk are dangerous
Dreams & Visions	Dreams of water mean change, falling dreams warn of pride, dreaming of someone means they're thinking of you

What common superstitions exist?

Lucky/unlucky numbers, colours, animals? Actions that invite bad fortune? Protective gestures or phrases?

YOUR ANSWER

What everyday rituals do people perform without thinking?

Knocking on wood, crossing fingers, small offerings, phrases spoken at certain moments:

YOUR ANSWER

What do people believe about dreams, omens, or signs?

WHAT DO PEOPLE BELIEVE ABOUT DREAMS, OMENS, OR SIGNS?

What folk remedies or beliefs exist around health, love, or fortune?

WHAT FOLK REMEDIES OR BELIEFS EXIST AROUND HEALTH, LOVE, OR FORTUNE?

Does a superstition or folk belief play a role in your characters' relationship?

A charm given as a gift, a shared ritual that becomes "their thing," a superstition one character finds endearing in the other. Small beliefs can create intimacy.

YOUR ANSWER



From what people believe to how they behave. Etiquette is where cultural values become visible in every interaction.

Manners, Etiquette & Everyday Politeness

Etiquette is an unwritten set of rules: which person says hello first, when does one stop speaking to allow another to go first. In romantasy, etiquette is a battleground. Each broken social rule reveals something about a character's origins, each deliberate violation is a statement of power, and the tension between what politeness requires and what desire demands drives countless charged scenes.

Show transgressions through reactions: the gasp, the shared look, the pause in conversation. A small social infraction is usually more effective than a large offence: the cutting remark, the incorrect form of address, the turned shoulder. And one character watching another learn the "rules" of a new world creates its own form of intimacy.

How do people greet each other?

RELATIONSHIP	GREETING
Strangers	
Acquaintances	
Friends	
Family	

RELATIONSHIP	GREETING
Superior to inferior (class/age/rank)	
Inferior to superior	

What's considered rude in everyday interaction?

Behaviours that give offence, things that aren't done:

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered polite or hospitable?

Offering food/drink to guests? Specific gestures of respect? Customs around visiting someone's home?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people handle conflict or disagreement?

Direct confrontation? Indirect communication? Mediation through third parties?

YOUR ANSWER

What social mistake does one character make that the other notices?

What faux pas creates a charged moment between them? Describe the mistake, who makes it, and how the other reacts.

(Write your answer below)



Manners govern everyday interactions, but hospitality governs the far more charged situation of entering someone else's space, and that dynamic is where many romantasy plots live.

Hospitality & Guest Rights

While it may seem like hospitality would be a minor detail when building a world, in romantasy it can be one of the most dependable ways to generate romantic tension. Both of your characters are continually entering into each other's space, and the obligations that come from being a guest or a host establish a precarious, intimate dynamic that has a lot of opportunity.

Hospitality is a social contract: the host provides safety, food, and shelter; the guest follows the host's rules and restrains their desires. Many fantasy worlds consider this contract sacred, and in Fae-inspired settings, hospitality can literally become a binding contract where each meal accepted or word of gratitude spoken creates obligation.

Hospitality builds romantic tension because both sides are vulnerable. The guest is dependent and visible; the host is exposed through their home. In *A Court of Thorns and Roses*, Feyre's stay at the Spring Court begins as hospitality-as-imprisonment: fine clothes and beautiful rooms, but no freedom. The contrast with the Night Court, where Rhysand declares her a guest rather than a prisoner and teaches her to defend herself, shows the difference between hospitality as control and hospitality as refuge.

Three hospitality patterns shape romantic dynamics: the **gilded cage** (luxury without autonomy), **the host's exposure** (the home reveals truths the host would rather hide), and **the violation** (one party breaks the sacred contract, and the betrayal cuts deeper because it occurred under the protection of hospitality). The more elaborate your welcoming rituals, the greater the weight when they're violated.

What does your culture owe a guest?

Protection? Food and shelter? Safe passage? How long do guest rights last? Is there a formal ritual of welcome that activates these obligations?

YOUR ANSWER

What does a guest owe their host?

Respect for house rules? Gifts? Restraint? What behaviour would violate guest rights? Are there things a guest must never do (ask certain questions, enter certain rooms, refuse offered food)?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when hospitality is violated?

By either party. What are the consequences of betraying a guest or dishonouring a host? Is the penalty social, legal, magical, or divine?

YOUR ANSWER

What threshold rituals exist in your world?

The more elaborate the welcoming ritual, the greater the weight when it's violated. What must happen when a guest arrives. What does it mean when someone skips a step?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your protagonist's guest status affect the romance?

Are they a willing guest, a reluctant one, or a prisoner in all but name? How does the power imbalance of guest and host shape the early dynamic between your characters?

YOUR ANSWER

Which hospitality pattern does your romance use?

These three patterns shape some of the most effective romantic dynamics in the genre. The gilded cage traps through luxury, the host’s exposure creates accidental vulnerability, and the violation cuts deepest because it breaks a sacred trust.

PATTERN	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW IT SHOWS UP IN YOUR STORY
The gilded cage (luxury without autonomy)		
The host’s exposure (home reveals truth)		
The violation (broken contract, deeper betrayal)		

Hospitality governs how characters enter each other's worlds. Entertainment governs what they do once they're there, and leisure is where many romances find their first excuse to spend time together.

Entertainment, Arts & Leisure

Leisure time provides natural settings for characters to meet outside their normal roles. A dance requires physical contact. A game reveals personality. A shared story creates inside jokes. Leisure activities often provide a "cover" for spending time together without acknowledging the real reason, and when a character develops an unexplained sudden interest in an art form their love interest practises, it's obvious to everyone else. The transparent nature of this behaviour adds to its charm.

◆ Core: What entertainment is common?

Leisure activities give your characters excuses to spend time together outside their normal roles. A dance requires touch. A game reveals personality. A shared story creates inside jokes. What does your world offer?
Music, theatre, games, sports, storytelling, gambling. What do people do for enjoyment?

YOUR ANSWER

What stories or legends does everyone know?

The cultural touchstones, tales children grow up hearing, references everyone understands:

YOUR ANSWER

What music exists? When is it played?

Instruments, styles, occasions for music:

YOUR ANSWER

What games or sports do people play?

WHAT GAMES OR SPORTS DO PEOPLE PLAY?

What art forms are valued?

Visual arts, crafts, performance, literature. What does this culture create and prize?

YOUR ANSWER

What leisure activity brings your characters together?

What activity gives them an excuse to spend time together? What does it allow – touch, conversation, competition? Does everyone else see through the excuse?

(Write your answer below)

Humour & Social Play

What makes people laugh reveals what they value, what they fear, and where the social fault lines run. Humour can bond characters instantly (a shared joke no one else gets) or divide them (a joke that lands as an insult across cultural lines). In romantasy, banter is often the first form of intimacy – it’s how characters test each other’s intelligence and boundaries before anything physical happens.

What makes people laugh in your world? What kind of humour is prized?

Wordplay and wit? Physical comedy? Dark humour? Sarcasm? Irreverence toward authority? What does “clever” look like here?

YOUR ANSWER

What jokes are told, and what do they reveal about the culture’s anxieties?

People joke about what they fear or resent. What topics show up in popular humour – class, magic, outsiders, the powerful?

YOUR ANSWER

What humour is off-limits or dangerous?

Mocking the gods? Joking about the monarch? Making light of death? What joke could get someone in real trouble?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your characters use humour with each other?

Is banter their first language of intimacy? Does one character's humour disarm the other? Does a joke ever land wrong between them?

YOUR ANSWER

Humour reveals what a culture values. Oaths reveal what it holds sacred. In romantasy, a sworn promise is often the immovable object that an irresistible romance collides with.

Oaths, Promises & Honour

In many romantasy worlds, people's words carry value. Culturally, socially, and at times magically. Oaths of allegiance, sworn promises, and honour debts often create commitments which have the potential to create direct conflicts with the heart's desires. This theme of a person's word as a contract is especially prevalent in Fae-inspired settings; spoken words are literal contracts. When a bargain is made correctly, under the right circumstances, it creates a binding obligation, and the definition of "equal" repayment can lie completely with the other party.

The romantic tension in oath culture comes from collision. As soon as a character's sworn duty and their growing love are mutually exclusive, the tension begins. A character who swore to protect the realm now loves someone the realm considers a threat. A character who promised their dying parent they'd marry for alliance now wants to marry for love. A guard assigned to protect someone's purity finds himself dismantling the very rules he swore to uphold.

Oaths have an inherent value in romantic tension because they were normally given when the character had no idea what they would be losing. The oath seemed like no big deal at the time, since the oath didn't conflict with anything the character wanted. It wasn't until the character develops romantic feelings for someone that the cost of the oath becomes apparent, and the commitment has already been made.

Oaths That Live in the Body

The strongest romantasy oaths aren't social norms; they have physical consequences. A deal manifests as a tattoo that can't be erased. Breaking a promise causes pain, sickness, or death. When your commitment lives in your body, the tension between responsibility and passion becomes unendurable. The distinction between "I will serve you" and "I will serve your interests" could be the difference between slavery and strategic alliance.

Rhysand and Feyre's bargain in *A Court of Thorns and Roses* is the genre's most compelling example. Feyre bargains herself away for one week each month, and the agreement is tattooed onto her body. When she avoids the Night Court, she deteriorates physically: nightmares, weight loss, illness. The bargain exists independently of feelings, and watching the obligation transform into something she wants is the slow burn at work.

The Loophole and the Letter of the Law

The loophole is one of the most rewarding elements of oath-based romance: the moment a character honours the letter of their promise while violating its spirit. Agency within constraint is the entire premise of romantasy. When creating your oath culture, consider where the tension between literal and implied meanings could create romantic conflict. Even in cultures where oaths are entirely symbolic, breaking a vow for love doesn't just cost a reputation; it costs an identity. The question becomes "Who am I if I break this?"

What oaths or promises bind your characters?

Military oaths? Family promises? Honour debts? Sworn service? Magical bargains? A promise to the dead?

What does breaking one's word cost in your culture?

Social disgrace? Exile? Loss of rank or magic? Physical pain? Somatic illness? Something worse?

YOUR ANSWER

Are oaths in your world purely cultural, or do they carry magical weight?

Can a bargain be literally binding? Does it manifest physically (a tattoo, a mark, a compulsion)? What happens if someone tries to break a magically enforced oath?

YOUR ANSWER

Does your world's oath system have loopholes?

Can precise wording be exploited? Is the letter or the spirit of the promise what matters? How might your characters use the system's rigidity to create space for personal choice?

YOUR ANSWER

What oath stands between your characters?

Which promise must be broken or bent for them to be together? Did the character know what they were giving up when they made it?

YOUR ANSWER

Write the oath.

Draft the actual words of the promise. Who was it sworn to? What was it supposed to mean? Now look for the loophole – what could those words literally mean that the speaker didn't intend?

(Write your answer below)

◆ Checkpoint: Social Rules & Obligations

Pause and review your answers on manners, hospitality, entertainment, and oaths. Are the social rules you've built consistent with the values you established in Part 1? If your culture prizes individual freedom but your hospitality customs are rigidly formal, decide which one gives. Or explain why the contradiction exists.

Oaths define what your characters have promised. Taboos define what they must never do, and in romantasy, those are often the same thing.

Taboos & Forbidden Things

The forbidden shows what the culture fears. In romantasy, taboos are the “forbidden love” stakes, and they’ll only be as effective as how well defined and important they are for each character involved.

Forbidden love has its excitement in the risk involved. Ensure that your reader understands the consequences of breaking the taboo for each character before they do so. The first transgression must feel dangerous. Subsequent transgressions may increase the risk, or they may make the previously forbidden become acceptable. Both options can be used; however, having an idea of which you plan to use is helpful.

◆ **Core: What behaviours are taboo in your world?**

Consider physical taboos (touch, proximity, eye contact), verbal taboos, social taboos, magical taboos, and sexual taboos.

(Write your answer below)

What happens when someone breaks a taboo?

Consequences should escalate with severity:

SEVERITY	CONSEQUENCE
Minor taboo broken	

SEVERITY	CONSEQUENCE
Moderate taboo broken	
Major taboo broken	

Which taboos directly affect your romance?

Pick 2-3 that create real obstacles and describe how each one gets in the way.

(Write your answer below)

What taboo do your characters break first?

This is often a pivotal early scene, the first boundary crossed:

YOUR ANSWER

What taboo must they break to be together fully?

This might be the climactic choice, the line they can't uncross:

YOUR ANSWER



Taboos mark where the line is. Sexuality norms determine how your culture polices desire itself, and that's often the most personal cage your characters must escape.

Sexuality, Desire & Intimacy Norms

Every society regulates desire. What counts as appropriate sexual behaviour, who can pursue whom, and what happens to those who violate these norms sit at the centre of romantic conflict in the genre. Purity culture is a potent tool in romantasy because a character battling the voice in her own head that tells her *wanting this makes me ruined* is fighting a very different kind of struggle than a character battling an external enemy.

A common structure is the **architecture of restriction**: the culture creates elaborate rules regarding the protagonist's sexuality (veils, chaperones, ritualistic practices, physical isolation) and the romance develops as the rules are slowly dismantled. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy is required to wear a veil, never be touched, never make eye contact. When Hawke arrives as her guard, the simplest contact – a glance, a casual conversation – takes on enormous transgression. Her rebellion begins not with a grand escape but a clandestine tavern visit wearing a mask, trading one concealment for another, simply to experience a kiss. The architecture of restriction makes even the smallest gestures of desire monumental.

The **double standard** is what gives these obstacles their teeth: in most romantasy worlds, the male love interest arrives with experience and no consequences, while the female protagonist's worth is determined by how little she knows. This creates tension in both directions. The protagonist must navigate internalised shame, while the love interest must prove worthy of trust.

The most powerful moment is when your protagonist recognises these norms for what they are. This connects to the Invisible Cage principle: the protagonist doesn't see the restriction as oppressive until they meet someone who views desire as normal. When writing the transition, frame the protagonist's choice as a reclaiming of agency rather than a loss of virtue, and give the protagonist their own desire and curiosity rather than treating them as a blank slate.

What are your culture's expectations around sexual behaviour?

Is virginity prized? For whom? What's the double standard? Are there visible markers of sexual status (clothing, rituals, titles)?

YOUR ANSWER

How are these norms enforced?

Social shame? Physical punishment? Religious consequence? Loss of status or marriageability? Who does the enforcing: family, religious authorities, the community at large?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens to someone who violates these norms?

Particularly for women. What are the consequences of being perceived as sexually transgressive? Are they the same for men?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your protagonist feel about wanting someone?

Do they feel shame? Freedom? Confusion? Curiosity they've been taught to suppress?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does the double standard live in your world?

What's permitted for one gender that would destroy the other? How does this asymmetry create tension between your characters?

BEHAVIOUR	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE PROTAGONIST	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE LOVE INTEREST
Being seen alone with someone		
Sexual experience/history		
Expressing desire openly		

What moment makes your protagonist see these norms differently?

Who or what shows them that wanting isn't something to be ashamed of? Is it a conversation, an experience, or seeing how someone else's culture handles desire?

YOUR ANSWER

Map the architecture of restriction, and the sequence of dismantling

If your protagonist lives under layers of rules designed to control their sexuality or intimacy, the romance develops as those layers are removed one by one. Map the restrictions from mildest to most extreme, then note which one falls first. Which one is the last to go?

LAYER OF RESTRICTION	WHAT RULE OR CUSTOM ENFORCES IT	WHEN DOES IT FALL IN THE STORY?
<i>The veil: Poppy can't be seen by anyone outside the temple</i>	<i>Maiden Law, enforced by the priestesses and her guards</i>	<i>Falls first: Hawke sees her face when assigned as her guard</i>
<i>No informal speech: the Maiden can't be addressed casually</i>	<i>Social custom, reinforced by everyone around her</i>	<i>Falls second: Hawke speaks to her like a person, not a title</i>
<i>No physical contact: she can't be touched by anyone</i>	<i>Maiden Law, with physical separation enforced by her quarters and guards</i>	<i>Falls late: each touch escalates the stakes</i>

What your characters do behind closed doors matters. But what other people *think* they do can matter just as much.

Reputation, Gossip & Public Opinion

In many cultures, how others perceive you can be just as important as your actions. Rumours spread quickly and reputation is often delicate. What once was, in some cases, could be irreversibly lost forever.

The way people react to your character when they enter a space can represent their feelings toward them. Does the room fall silent? Do people move closer or edge away? The quiet, unspoken comments your character can't quite catch will heighten the reader's tension. Represent the pressure of the public's perception with the subtleties: the small, almost unnoticed slights, the intentional glances, and the closing of the door.

How does information travel in your society?

HOW DOES INFORMATION TRAVEL IN YOUR SOCIETY?

What destroys a reputation?

What scandal follows someone forever? What would destroy someone in the protagonist's position? The love interest's position? Is it the same for all classes and genders?

(Write your answer below)

Can a ruined reputation be recovered? How?

Some cultures allow redemption; others don't. Is there a path back, or is ruin permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

Who are the gossips and rumormongers in your story?

Who spreads information, maliciously or carelessly? Who might your characters need to avoid, bribe, or silence?

YOUR ANSWER

What rumors might circulate about your characters' relationship?

Even if nothing has happened yet, what might people *say* is happening?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the worst rumor that could circulate about each character?

The thing that would destroy them – true or not.

(Write your answer below)

How do your characters protect their reputations while pursuing each other?

What precautions do they take? What lies do they tell? What image do they maintain?

YOUR ANSWER

Reputation is shaped by what people see. Privacy determines how much they get to see, and how hard your characters must work to find moments alone.

Privacy, Surveillance & Being Watched

Privacy is earned in most romantasy worlds, and that scarcity is what makes every stolen moment matter. A near-discovery builds tension: the footsteps in the hallway, the knock on the door, the voice in the next room. The process of creating privacy together – discovering a secluded place, fabricating reasons to be alone, learning each other's schedules – is itself a form of intimacy.

How much privacy exists in your world?

Consider: Do servants see everything? Do nobles have private chambers? Do commoners share living spaces? Is magical surveillance possible?

YOUR ANSWER

Where are people always watched?

Courts, public spaces, family homes, workplaces. Where is privacy impossible?

YOUR ANSWER

Who might be watching or listening?

Servants, guards, family members, rivals, magical surveillance, spies:

YOUR ANSWER

Where can your characters be alone together?

List the spaces where privacy is possible and the risk of discovery at each location.

(Write your answer below)

What would happen if they were seen together?

CONTEXT	CONSEQUENCE
Seen talking privately	
Seen alone together	
Seen in physical contact	

What excuse or cover story do they use when almost caught?

WHAT EXCUSE OR COVER STORY DO THEY USE WHEN ALMOST CAUGHT?

Is there a moment in your story when they ARE seen?

Who sees them? What happens next?

YOUR ANSWER

You've mapped where your characters can be alone. Now define what they can and can't do when they get there.

Physical & Romantic Boundaries

Touch, proximity, gestures, and tokens all work together to form your culture's romantic code. When a simple brush of fingers is taboo, it carries a charge that explicit contact in a more permissive culture can't match. When a specific gift or garment signals courtship, giving or wearing it becomes a declaration. The more forbidden these signals are, the more weight each one carries.

What touch is considered appropriate between unmarried people?

Map the boundaries:

CATEGORY	WHAT'S INCLUDED
Always acceptable	

CATEGORY	WHAT'S INCLUDED
Acceptable in certain contexts (chaperoned, public, formal)	
Borderline or scandalous	
Absolutely forbidden	

What physical distance is expected between unmarried people?

WHAT PHYSICAL DISTANCE IS EXPECTED BETWEEN UNMARRIED PEOPLE?

What touch feels more intimate than a kiss in your world?

Every culture has its own unexpected intimacy. What's yours?

YOUR ANSWER

Are unmarried people allowed to be alone together?

If no, who must be present? Under what circumstances can they be unchaperoned? If they ARE alone together, what does that imply?

YOUR ANSWER

What gestures signal romantic interest, and what crosses the line?

This is your culture's romantic body language. For the full courtship progression (who initiates, expected steps, family involvement), see Courtship Customs below. For courtship gifts and tokens, see Tokens, Gifts & Symbols.

GESTURE TYPE	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Acceptable signals of interest	

GESTURE TYPE	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Borderline, could be read as too forward	
Clearly transgressive, would cause scandal	

Who acts as chaperone for your characters?

Is this person sympathetic, oblivious, or hostile to the romance? How do the characters evade supervision?

YOUR ANSWER



When do your characters first break a physical or romantic boundary?

Describe the scene. What boundary do they cross? Was it intentional or accidental? How do they react?

YOUR ANSWER

What touch do they share in private that they couldn't share in public?

The contrast between public restraint and private contact creates tension:

YOUR ANSWER

What romantic gesture does one character make that surprises the other?

Something that reveals more than they intended, or that the other didn't expect:

YOUR ANSWER

◆ **Checkpoint: Boundaries & Identity**

Review your answers on taboos, sexuality, reputation, privacy, and touch. Do the boundaries you've built escalate logically. Is a forbidden glance less dangerous than forbidden touch, which is less dangerous than a forbidden night together? If two taboos contradict each other, resolve that now.

Physical boundaries govern what touch means. Dress and appearance govern what the body itself communicates before anyone is touched at all.

Dress, Appearance & Adornment

Dressing tells us who we are: our social standing, how available we are, our values and beliefs. Clothing also creates its own romantic tension. The veil that can't be removed, the colour that says "don't speak to me," the hair that only your spouse can see unbound.

Dress in detail and observe what your characters pay attention to when it comes to each other's clothes. What your protagonist focuses on with regards to another character's appearance will give your readers an idea of where their eyes keep going back to: how fabric falls, a scar that's hidden under the edge of a collar, a ring that is or isn't being worn.

Transitions in wardrobe also serve well as indicators of how intimate the relationship has become. Armour removed, hair unbound, formal wear discarded. Each layer of clothing that's removed is a layer of distance that's been removed.

What Clothing Signals

What does clothing tell you about a person?

What markers indicate class, profession, marital status, and religion?

(Write your answer below)

Are there sumptuary laws, rules about who can wear what?

Certain fabrics, colours, or styles restricted to certain classes? Penalties for dressing "above your station"?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean for your character to dress outside their station?

Disguise? Scandal? Crime? Social death?

YOUR ANSWER

What do people actually wear?

You don't need every stitch – just know enough to make descriptions feel true. How does clothing differ between wealthy and common people for daily life, formal events, work, and celebrations?

(Write your answer below)

For historical fashion terminology (chemise, doublet, kirtle, stays, etc.), see Section 20: Quick Reference Sheets.

What are your world's distinctive garments?

What clothing exists in your world that doesn't exist in ours? Magical garments? Cultural specifics?

YOUR ANSWER

Beauty & Attractiveness

Every culture has its own definition of beauty, and those standards shape how your characters see themselves and each other. What's considered attractive often reflects deeper values: a warrior culture may prize scars and strength; a court culture may prize pale skin and delicate hands. When your protagonist finds someone beautiful in a way their culture wouldn't endorse, it reveals something about who they really are.

What does your culture consider physically beautiful?

Think about body type, skin, hair, features, bearing. How do beauty standards differ between genders?

YOUR ANSWER

How do beauty standards differ by class, region, or species?

Does the court ideal differ from the rural ideal? Do different peoples prize different traits? Is there a "look" associated with power or wealth?

YOUR ANSWER

What physical trait does your protagonist find attractive in the love interest that surprises them or defies the cultural standard?

WHAT PHYSICAL TRAIT DOES YOUR PROTAGONIST FIND ATTRACTIVE IN THE LOVE INTEREST THAT SURPRISES THEM OR DEFIES THE CULTURAL STANDARD?

What does your culture consider ugly, flawed, or undesirable – and how does that affect someone's romantic prospects?

WHAT DOES YOUR CULTURE CONSIDER UGLY, FLAWED, OR UNDESIRABLE -- AND HOW DOES THAT AFFECT SOMEONE'S ROMANTIC PROSPECTS?

Covered & Revealed

What parts of the body are typically covered?

What's modest dress in your culture? Does it differ by gender, class, or context?

YOUR ANSWER

What's considered scandalous or provocative to reveal?

WHAT'S CONSIDERED SCANDALOUS OR PROVOCATIVE TO REVEAL?

What does revealing something usually hidden mean?

If someone shows skin they normally cover, what does that signal? Trust? Intimacy? Invitation? Shame?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there something one character shows the other that they don't show anyone else?

A physical vulnerability? A hidden mark? Simply their unguarded appearance?

YOUR ANSWER

Hair & Its Meanings

What do hairstyles signify in your culture?

Bound vs. loose? Cut vs. uncut? Covered vs. uncovered? Specific styles for specific statuses?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there significance to who can touch someone's hair?

Is it intimate? Forbidden? Reserved for family or spouse?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment when one character sees the other's hair differently than usual?

Unbound, wet, disheveled, cut, and what does it mean?

YOUR ANSWER

Undressing as Intimacy

What does it mean to see someone in states of undress?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN TO SEE SOMEONE IN STATES OF UNDRRESS?

When do your characters first see each other less than fully dressed?

What are the circumstances? What does each see?

YOUR ANSWER

What layers come off over the course of the relationship?

Map the progression from the first small reveal to the moment when they're fully unguarded. Describe an early, middle, and late-stage moment where something is removed or revealed.

(Write your answer below)

Is there a garment that represents armor or protection that one character removes around the other?

Literal armor? A mask? Formal court dress? Religious garments? What does removing it signify?

YOUR ANSWER



You've defined what the body says and what it wears. Now define the script your culture has written for how love is supposed to proceed.

Courtship Customs & Romantic Expectations

All cultures have a romantic script: the expected ways to indicate interest and the approved sequence from stranger to spouse. The romantic tension comes from the gap between what's expected and what's felt. Characters who are acutely aware of which step they're on, frustrated with a rigid pacing that doesn't match their feelings, constantly calculating whether they can skip ahead. Once a couple deviates from the script, it should be apparent that both know what they're doing. The script becomes most important once they deviate from it.

◆ Core: How do people show romantic interest?

What's the cultural script for "I'm interested in you"?

YOUR ANSWER

◆ Core: What's the expected progression of a relationship?

Map the steps from "strangers" to "married":

Who initiates courtship?

One gender? Either? Families? Does it vary by class?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the role of family in courtship?

Must families approve? Arrange meetings? Give formal consent? Or do individuals choose freely?

YOUR ANSWER

How long is a typical courtship?

Weeks? Months? Years? Is a long courtship expected, or can people marry quickly?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your characters violate courtship expectations?

Do they skip steps? Move too fast? Pursue when they shouldn't? Ignore family involvement?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when someone skips steps or moves too fast?

What signals does it send when someone rushes courtship, skips family involvement, or pursues someone above their station?

(Write your answer below)



Courtship provides the script. Tokens and gifts are the physical objects that make intentions tangible, and permanent.

Tokens, Gifts & Symbols

Gifts in courtship are their own form of communication. Each gift scene has three components worth slowing down through: the giving (nervous or confident?), the receiving (recognition or confusion?), and the aftermath (where does the gift go, how often is it touched?). A gift that reflects the giver's awareness of the receiver – a remembered preference, a noticed need – will always land harder than an expensive gift that merely demonstrates wealth.

Are there traditional courtship gifts or tokens?

What objects carry romantic meaning? (Flowers, jewelry, handkerchiefs, enchanted items, etc.)

YOUR ANSWER

What does giving or accepting such a token signify?

Interest? Serious intent? Engagement? Binding commitment?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either of your characters give such a token, or refuse one?

What happens and what does it mean?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there an object that becomes meaningful to your couple specifically?

Not a traditional token, but something that gains significance between them:

YOUR ANSWER

Plan a gift scene.

Slow down through all three stages: the giving (nervous or confident?), the receiving (recognition or confusion?), and the aftermath (where does the gift go, how often is it touched?). What's the gift, and why this gift specifically?

(Write your answer below)



Tokens declare intent. Marriage is what makes it official, and the ceremony itself is where private love becomes a public act.

Marriage Customs & Ceremonies

Marriage is where individualised love becomes a public rite of passage. Who can marry whom? What rituals must be performed? What makes a union legitimate? These customs define the endgame of your romance and the obstacles standing in its way.

These customs shape whether your characters are rushing towards marriage or trying to escape it. Weddings create great set-piece moments. Since they're public, the ceremony can increase tension: the vows have to be said out loud, the witnesses can watch for hesitation, the moment when an objection can be raised. No matter whether the couple is getting married with open arms or against their will, the ceremony should have a sense of finality. Take your time to describe what your character sees, hears, and feels during the ceremony, and let the ritual carry the emotional weight.

♦ Core: What makes a marriage “real” in cultural terms, beyond legal requirements?

Religious ceremony? Community witness? Consummation? Exchange of vows? Magical binding? Family blessing?

YOUR ANSWER

Describe a traditional wedding ceremony in your world.

Where does it happen? Who performs it? What are the key rituals? What vows are spoken? What objects or symbols are used?

(Write your answer below)

What happens after the ceremony?

Reception? Consummation rituals? Wedding night traditions? Period of seclusion?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there different marriage customs for different classes, species, or magical groups?

If so, what are the key differences?

YOUR ANSWER

Can marriages be dissolved? How?

Divorce, annulment, magical unbinding? What does it cost, and who suffers more – socially, financially, spiritually?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters marry, how does their ceremony differ from tradition?

Do they follow all customs, some, or none? What does this choice reveal?

YOUR ANSWER



Can people marry secretly or elope?

Is this culturally acceptable, scandalous, or meaningless without public recognition?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a secret marriage feel “real” to the people in it?

Even without official ceremony, what ritual or words would make it meaningful?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters had a secret ceremony, what would it look like?

Where would it happen? What would they say or do? Who (if anyone) would witness?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Do the marriage customs here match the legal requirements in your government? If your government regulates who can marry, requires permits, or bans certain unions, those laws should align with, or deliberately conflict with, the cultural customs above. See Section 5: Government, Power & Law.



◆ Checkpoint: Courtship & Commitment

Look back at your courtship customs, tokens, and marriage traditions. Does the progression make sense. Do the steps from first interest to marriage build logically? Does your secret marriage option (if you have one) actually conflict with your public ceremony, or could characters easily have both? Tension lives in the gap between what's felt and what's allowed.



Marriage marks the beginning of a shared life. Death marks its end, and how your culture handles loss shapes what love means when it lasts beyond a lifetime.

Death, Grief & Mourning

Death customs shape how a culture approaches romance at its most emotional. Rituals surrounding the dead, what is owed to the deceased, whether grief is performed publicly or hidden away, and whether remarriage is permitted or shameful will all influence your romance. What your characters believe about the end of life colours how they view love.

The most direct romantic obstacle is the **mourning period**: a socially or magically enforced time where the bereaved are separated from the world of romance. In romantasy, mourning customs can be highly restrictive, including prohibitions against dancing, socialising, wearing colours, and being visible in public. Developing romantic feelings during this time carries guilt, because wanting someone while grieving is seen as betrayal of the deceased.

Death customs also define character. How your characters treat the dead reveals who they are at their deepest level. A character willing to risk their safety to retrieve a body for proper burial shows capacity for selfless caring. A character who refuses outward mourning but displays deep grief in private reads as emotionally honest and complex. When two characters grieve together, the experience creates a bond unlike anything else: they have witnessed each other completely raw, with no social masks.

What are the mourning customs in your world?

How long is the mourning period? What mourning dress or symbols are used? What restrictions apply – social, romantic, business?

(Write your answer below)

How does your culture treat the dead?

Burial, cremation, sky burial, magical dissolution? Is there a ritual that must be performed? What happens if the rites aren't completed? Does it affect the dead, the living, or both?

YOUR ANSWER

What are the rules around loving again after loss?

Is remarriage permitted? Expected? Shameful? Does it depend on how long they wait, who died, or how they died?

YOUR ANSWER

Can someone in mourning pursue romance?

Is courtship forbidden during mourning? For how long? What happens if they violate this?

YOUR ANSWER

How does grief affect your characters or their relationship?

If one character is mourning, how does this impact what's possible between them? Does shared grief bring them together?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your characters treat the dead they encounter?

A character who pauses to close a stranger's eyes or say a prayer reveals something about their capacity for tenderness. A character who walks past without looking reveals something too.

YOUR ANSWER



Death marks the end of a life's journey. Coming of age marks its true beginning, the moment a character becomes eligible for everything that follows.

Life Stages & Coming of Age

Each culture establishes a point at which an individual is no longer a child, and that threshold indicates when they become eligible for romance, responsibility, and independent choice. The traditions surrounding this transition are crucial to understanding your character's past and can provide a pivotal moment within your story.

These transitions also establish natural turning points. A character who wasn't allowed to marry yesterday may have no problem getting married today, and that creates decisions they weren't prepared to face. The transition from childhood to adulthood could occur over a single night. In romantasy, the coming-of-age moment often coincides with the beginning of the romantic plot: the character becomes eligible, visible, or available in a way they weren't before.

What marks the transition to adulthood?

Age? Ceremony? Achievement? Magical awakening? Physical maturity?

YOUR ANSWER

What can people do as adults that they couldn't do as children?

Marry without consent? Own property? Make contracts? Use certain magic? Live independently?

YOUR ANSWER

Are your characters considered adults?

If not, how does this create obstacles? Are they defying expectations by acting before they're "ready"?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there other significant life transitions that affect your story?

Coming-of-age ceremonies, magical awakenings, trials, presentations at court, etc.?

YOUR ANSWER

Does a life transition trigger the romantic plot?

Does your character become eligible for courtship, gain new powers, or enter a new social context? How does this change what's possible between them and the love interest?

YOUR ANSWER

Coming of age determines when your characters enter adult life. Education and work determine what kind of adult life they enter, and whether their paths will cross.

Daily Roles & Education

How a culture raises its children and organises its labour reveals what it values most. A child raised to fight shows affection differently than one raised to charm, and a culture that locks people into inherited professions creates different romantic obstacles than one where anyone can reinvent themselves. The way your characters were brought up shaped them into the adults they are, and when two characters discuss how they would raise children together, they reveal their deepest values.

How are children educated, and how does that lead to adult roles?

CLASS/GROUP	HOW THEY'RE EDUCATED	WHAT WORK THEY DO AS ADULTS
Noble/wealthy	<i>e.g., Private tutors in languages, history, etiquette</i>	<i>e.g., Governance, military command, court politics</i>
Middle/merchant		
Common/poor	<i>e.g., Learn parents' trade by working alongside them</i>	<i>e.g., Farming, crafts, manual labour</i>
Magical children		

How do most people learn skills and knowledge?

Apprenticeship? Formal schools? Family teaching? Religious institutions?

YOUR ANSWER

Who has access to education, and what knowledge is valued vs. dismissed?

Is literacy common? Are schools available to all classes? Is book learning respected more than practical skills, or the reverse?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there institutions that take children from their families?

Temples, military academies, magical schools, noble fostering arrangements? What does separation mean?

YOUR ANSWER

What professions are respected? Looked down upon?

STATUS	PROFESSIONS
Highly respected	
Respectable	
Necessary but low-status	
Disreputable or shameful	

How do people typically end up in their professions?

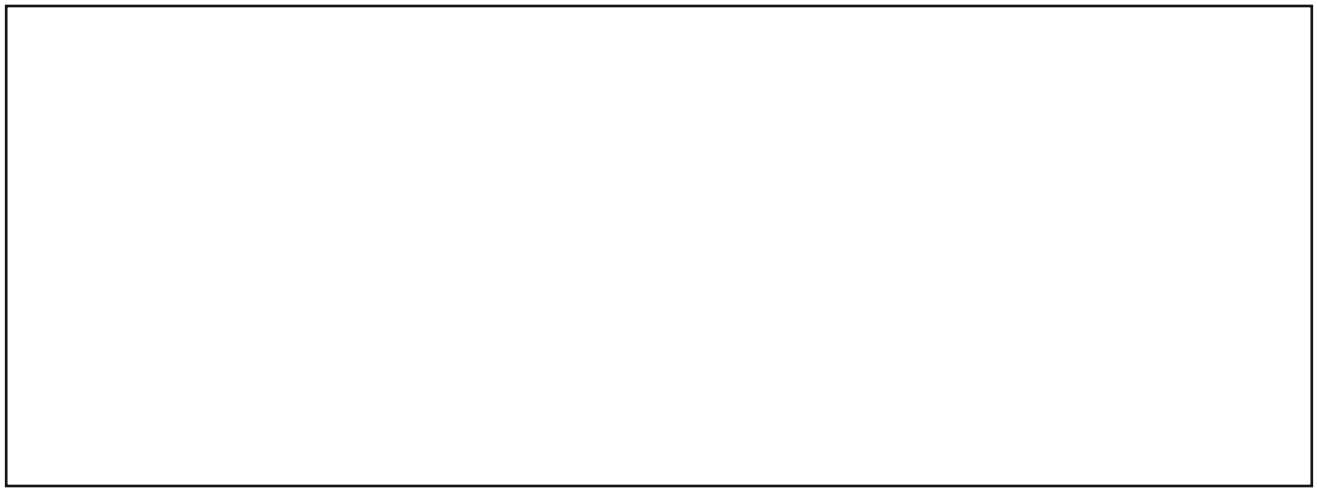
Family tradition? Personal choice? Assignment? Class restrictions?

YOUR ANSWER

How were your protagonist and love interest raised, and what do they do now?

What was childhood like for each of them? What skills did they gain, what gaps does each have, and how do they spend their working hours? Does their work bring them together or keep them apart?

(Write your answer below)



You've built the foundations of your culture and mapped the milestones of your characters' lives. Now it's time to put that culture into motion, through the events, consequences, and social dynamics that drive your romance forward.

PART TWO: CULTURE & ROMANCE

Festivals, Holidays & Celebrations

Festivals are classic romance settings because rules relax, emotions heighten, and everyone is gathered in one place. A mask hides identity, a dance requires touch, a tradition pairs strangers together. These customs give characters excuses for intimacy they couldn't otherwise justify, and the urgency of a festival ending – this chance won't come again – drives pivotal scenes.

What major festivals or celebrations exist in your world?

Describe 1-3 that matter for your story. For each, when does it happen, what does it celebrate, and what are the key traditions?

(Write your answer below)

Do festivals allow any relaxation of normal rules?

Masquerades where identity is hidden? Festivals where class mingles? Nights when normal rules are suspended?

YOUR ANSWER

Which festival provides a romantic opportunity for your characters, and why?

WHICH FESTIVAL PROVIDES A ROMANTIC OPPORTUNITY FOR YOUR CHARACTERS, AND WHY?

What festival tradition do your characters participate in together?

Describe the scene:

YOUR ANSWER

Festivals celebrate belonging. Exile is what happens when belonging is revoked, and that threat is the highest stake your culture can impose on a forbidden romance.

Exile, Banishment & Social Death

Every society uses a most extreme form of punishment to dissuade individuals from violating the norms: total removal from society. Exile, banishment, and social death represent the ultimate consequence of choosing love over community, and the fear of being exiled provides actual weight to each transgression. This is the nuclear

option. Every time your characters violate a societal norm, the possibility of exile is what makes even the smallest violations feel dangerous.

Exile in romantasy takes several forms, and the form matters for your romance:

- **Political banishment:** The state exerts its power by physically removing the character from the territory through decree, forcing them to survive in an unfamiliar or hostile environment.
- **Self-imposed exile:** A character who voluntarily becomes a pariah to protect others, hiding behind a villain's mask, leaving home to keep a secret safe. The cost is reputation and identity, and the romantic obstacle is that the love interest must see past the performance to the real person underneath.
- **Social ostracism:** The character remains physically present but is treated as invisible, contaminated, or dead. Generational guilt, racial branding, or species-based prejudice mark them as permanent outsiders within their own community.
- **Cultural divorce:** The character rejects the beliefs, religion, or traditions of their people. They're not cast out by others; they walk away. But the safety net vanishes, and the romantic relationship must replace the entire support structure they've abandoned.

What makes exile such a potent romantic stake is that it forces a character to redefine who they are without their community, title, or social position. That vulnerability is also the prerequisite for the kind of raw honesty the strongest romances require.

Jude's exile at the end of *The Wicked King* illustrates this perfectly. Cardan sends her back to the mortal world, stripping away her status, authority, and sense of purpose. The exile comes directly from the love interest, making it both deeply personal and politically motivated. When Jude returns, her restoration as High Queen carries greater weight because she earned it back from nothing.

The threat of exile is often more useful to your story than exile itself. You don't need to exile your protagonist to make exile matter. You just need to show them what exile looks like: a disowned sibling, a shunned former courtier, someone whose name is no longer spoken.

When building exile customs, think about what the banished person loses beyond location. Name? Family connections? Access to magic? Their place in the afterlife? The more exile strips away, the more your character risks by pursuing a forbidden relationship. And consider what replaces the lost community: in many romantasy stories, the romance provides not just a partner but a found family, a new world built on choice rather than inheritance.

♦ **Core: What does banishment or exile look like in your world?**

Physical exile from the territory? Social death while remaining present? Being cut off from family, magic, or community? Loss of name, title, or identity? Inherited stigma that marks the next generation?

YOUR ANSWER

What triggers banishment?

What transgression crosses the line from punishable to unforgivable? Is there a formal process, or can it happen at one person's command?

YOUR ANSWER

Has your character seen someone else face this consequence?

Showing the cost through a secondary character makes the threat real before your protagonists face it. Who in your world has already been cast out, and what happened to them?

YOUR ANSWER

Is exile reversible in your world?

Can the banished return? What would it cost? Is there a path to redemption, or are some falls permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

What replaces the lost community?

If your character is exiled, where do they go? Who takes them in? Does the romance provide not just a partner but a new world to belong to?

YOUR ANSWER

Map your character's exile (actual or threatened).

What do they lose? Think about home, name, family connections, access to magic or power, community, sense of self. What replaces what they've lost?

(Write your answer below)

Attitudes Toward Outsiders

How a culture treats people who are “other” – different species, races, magical traditions, nationalities – shapes some of the most powerful romantic conflicts in the genre. Forbidden love across cultural or species lines draws its tension from prejudice, fear, and the cost of being seen with someone your world says you shouldn’t want.

How does your culture view other species, races, or magical traditions?

Is there open hostility, polite distance, grudging tolerance, or genuine curiosity? What stereotypes exist, and how much truth do they hold?

YOUR ANSWER

What’s the lived experience of being “other” in your world?

What daily indignities, restrictions, or dangers does an outsider face? Where are they welcome, and where are they not?

YOUR ANSWER

If one of your characters is considered an outsider, how does that status shape the romance?

Does the other character have to overcome their own prejudice? Does the relationship put both of them at risk? What does it cost each of them to be seen together?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it take for an outsider to be genuinely accepted – and is that acceptance even possible?

WHAT WOULD IT TAKE FOR AN OUTSIDER TO BE GENUINELY ACCEPTED -- AND IS THAT ACCEPTANCE EVEN POSSIBLE?

Exile and outsider status define the extremes. Social hierarchy defines the everyday power dynamics your characters navigate in every interaction.

Social Hierarchy in Practice

Social hierarchy creates unwritten rules: who enters the room first, who speaks and who waits, who may touch whom. None of this is written into a law book, yet most people understand these codes and follow them. When members of different classes fall in love, the tension stems from the disconnect between the roles they're obligated to follow and what they actually feel.

Illustrate hierarchy through automatic behaviours and the moments when those behaviours break. The “slip” – when a character accidentally uses a first name, reaches for a hand, or speaks before permission – reveals the true nature beneath the social mask. When characters display perfect hierarchy in public but drop it in private, they create their own secret world. Let secondary characters reinforce the consequences: a servant who observes too much, a rival tracking every detail, a parent warning “people are starting to talk.”

What are the unwritten rules between different classes or ranks?

Think about eye contact, forms of address, physical proximity, who speaks first, and what topics are off-limits. (Write your answer below)

What happens when someone violates these unwritten rules?

Social consequences: awkwardness, offence, whispers, retaliation:

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters are from different classes, how do they navigate interaction?

Do they follow the rules? Chafe against them? Have a private space where class doesn't apply?

YOUR ANSWER

What social space allows them to interact more freely than usual?

Markets? Festivals? Neutral territory? Magical spaces? Private chambers?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the “slip” look like between your characters?

Describe a moment when a character breaks a class or rank rule without meaning to – a first name used without thinking, a hand reached for instinctively. What’s the slip, who makes it, who notices, and what does it reveal?

(Write your answer below)

How do your characters behave differently in public versus private?

What does the shift look like when the door closes? What would happen if someone saw the private version?

(Write your answer below)

Cross-check: Does the class structure you described here match the economic system you built in Section 4: Economy, Labour & Resources? If wealth determines status, the paths to wealth should align with who holds power in your hierarchy.



◆ Checkpoint: Culture in Action

You've now built festivals, exile stakes, and social hierarchy. Do your festival traditions actually reflect the values from Part 1? Does your exile system connect to the taboos you defined earlier? If breaking a taboo should lead to exile but your exile section describes different triggers, reconcile them now.



Hierarchy governs who has power. Language governs how that power sounds, and the shift from formal to informal address can be as intimate as any touch.

Language, Names & Forms of Address

The transition from formal to informal address can be as profound as a first kiss. In many fantasy worlds, names hold real power. Establish formality at the beginning and let it create tension. The moment of shift should have context: who initiated it, was it asked for or assumed, and what does it feel like to hear your first name from someone who has only ever used your title?

What different forms of address exist?

TYPE	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Formal (titles, honorifics, surnames)	
Informal (first names, nicknames)	
Intimate (pet names, private names, terms of endearment)	

When is it appropriate to use informal or intimate forms?

Between family? Close friends? Lovers? Only after marriage?

YOUR ANSWER

What shift in address marks a change in relationship?

From title to first name? From formal to informal? A new nickname?

YOUR ANSWER

When do your characters shift how they address each other?

What do they call each other at first, what do they shift to, and what triggers the change?

(Write your answer below)

Is there significance to names in your world?

True names with power? Secret names? Multiple names for different contexts?

YOUR ANSWER

What does it mean when one character learns the other's private or true name?

WHAT DOES IT MEAN WHEN ONE CHARACTER LEARNS THE OTHER'S PRIVATE OR TRUE NAME?



Everything so far has focused on a single culture's rules. If your characters come from different cultures, the collision between those rule systems is where some of your richest conflict lives.

Cultural Differences Between Characters

Do your characters come from different cultural backgrounds?

If no, skip to Integration Check.

If yes:

What culture does each character come from?

(Write your answer below)

How do their cultures differ in values, customs, and taboos?

(Write your answer below)

What does one culture do that the other finds shocking, rude, or confusing?

Describe 2-3 cultural misunderstandings that could arise between your characters.

(Write your answer below)

What romantic gesture from one culture means something different in the other?

This is prime territory for miscommunication and eventual understanding:

YOUR ANSWER

When do they realise they've been misunderstanding each other?

The revelation scene:

YOUR ANSWER

What cultural tradition does one character teach the other?

The intimacy of sharing worlds:

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

How does culture connect to the rest of your world?

Pick the connections that matter most for your story: How does government enforce cultural norms? How does magic interact with customs? How do economic realities shape what people can do? What customs have religious origins?

(Write your answer below)

Quick Reference: Cultural Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Core cultural value that most affects your romance	
Main taboo your characters break	
The reputation risk	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The touch or proximity rule that creates tension	
The courtship custom they follow or violate	
The festival or ceremony that matters	
The form of address shift (from → to → when)	
The oath or promise that conflicts with love	
The cultural attitude toward desire that your protagonist must navigate	

Final Thought

Culture Is Behaviour, Not Exposition

Don't info-dump culture. Show it through action: characters following or breaking rules, social awkwardness when norms are violated. The best cultural worldbuilding is invisible until someone breaks the rules, and then everyone knows exactly what line was crossed.



What's Next

You've built the cultural fabric your characters live inside, the values they were raised on, the rules they follow, the customs that shape every relationship. Now it's time to look at the systems that enforce and fund that culture.

- **Section 4: Economy, Labour & Resources.** Who has money and who doesn't? Economic class shapes everything from courtship prospects to daily routines. If class divides your characters, start here.
- **Section 5: Government, Power & Law.** Who makes the rules your characters are breaking? Government determines which cultural norms have legal teeth and which are purely social pressure.
- **Section 6: Religion, Myth & Prophecy.** If religion shapes your characters' daily lives, expand on the theology, institutions, and prophecies that underpin those habits.
- **Section 9: Technology & Infrastructure.** Daily life depends on what's available. Lighting, transportation, communication: these shape what a "typical day" actually looks like.
- **Section 12: Designing Your Key Locations.** The places where your cultural rules play out. Markets, temples, courts, and homes all need to reflect the customs you've built here.